

The Ship of Theseus: Puzzles of Identity Over Time

An original lesson plan inspired by **André Gallois's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Identity Over Time. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or André Gallois. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/identity-time/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Metaphysics

"If every plank of a ship is gradually replaced, is the repaired ship still the same ship it always was — and what does 'the same' even mean over time?"

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the distinction between numerical and qualitative identity, and state the classic Ship of Theseus and statue/clay puzzles in premise form.
- Apply the endurantist and perdurantist accounts of persistence to the two-ship version of the Ship of Theseus to determine what each says about which ship, if either, survives.
- Evaluate the constitution view against the endurantist and perdurantist alternatives and defend a position on which best handles the statue/clay case.

Materials Needed

- Modeling clay and a small pre-formed clay figure, used as a physical prop
- Diagram handout of the Ship of Theseus (planks replaced one by one, plus a second ship reassembled from the discarded originals)
- Whiteboard for endurantist vs. perdurantist diagrams (objects as points in time vs. objects as four-dimensional "worms")
- Index cards for a persistence-puzzle sorting activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Clay Statue

8 min

Using the physical clay, form it into a statue shape in front of the class ("Goliath"), then squash it back into a lump ("Lump"). Ask: when Goliath was squashed, did Goliath cease to exist even though the clay itself, Lump, obviously still exists? Poll the room before explaining further.

Direct Instruction: Numerical Identity and the Ship

15 min

Distinguish numerical identity (being one and the same thing) from qualitative identity (being exactly similar). Introduce the Ship of Theseus in its two-part version: a ship whose planks are replaced one at a time during repairs, alongside a rival ship secretly reassembled from all the original discarded planks. Pose the puzzle of which resulting ship, if either, counts as "the real" original.

Small-Group Analysis: Endurantism vs. Perdurantism

20 min

Explain the two main pictures of persistence: *endurantism* (an object is "wholly present" at every moment of its existence, the very same whole thing enduring through time) and *perdurantism* (an object is a four-dimensional "space-time worm" made of temporal parts, so "the ship at noon" is just one slice of a longer object). Groups apply both views to the two-ship puzzle and the statue/clay case and report which view handles each case more naturally, and what cost it pays.

Whole-Class Synthesis

12 min

Introduce the constitution view as a third option: the statue and the lump of clay are two distinct-but-coinciding objects sharing the same matter but differing in their identity and persistence conditions. Compare its cost — multiplying the number of objects in the same place — against the costs of *endurantism* and *perdurantism*.

Closure

5 min

Exit ticket: students apply one of the three frameworks to a new case of their choosing — a renovated house, a river, a repaired childhood toy — and briefly justify their answer.

Discussion Questions

- 1 In the two-ship version of the Ship of Theseus, is the continuously-repaired ship or the reassembled-from-original-parts ship the "real" original — or does the puzzle show that "same ship" was never a fully precise notion to begin with?
- 2 Is it more plausible that Goliath (the statue) and Lump (the clay) are strictly one and the same thing, or two distinct objects that merely coincide in the same place at the same time? What follows from each answer?
- 3 Does *perdurantism*'s idea that objects are four-dimensional "worms" with temporal parts solve persistence puzzles too easily, by treating questions about one enduring thing as differences between time-slices instead?
- 4 Are our ordinary judgments about "the same object" — the same car, the same river, the same self — simply imprecise in ways formal metaphysics reveals, or is metaphysics over-thinking something ordinary language already handles fine?
- 5 Does the gradual, one-piece-at-a-time nature of change suggest that identity over time might be a matter of degree rather than all-or-nothing?

Assessment

Students choose one persistence puzzle from class — the two-ship Ship of Theseus, or the statue/clay case — and write a short paper defending either the endurantist, perdurantist, or constitution-view answer to it, explicitly naming and responding to the strongest objection to their chosen answer. Grade on accurate use of the relevant metaphysical vocabulary and genuine engagement with a rival view.

Extension Activity

Have students find a real object in their own life that has undergone significant part-replacement or renovation over time — a family car, a repaired instrument, a renovated home — and write a short reflection applying the endurantist, perdurantist, and constitution frameworks to whether it counts as "the same" object today.

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